THE NEW DIRTY DOZEN

A host of harmful additives and preservatives hide behind seemingly healthy food labels and marketing claims

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Ingredients to Watch Out For...



1 PHOSPHATE ADDITIVES/ POLYPHOSPHATES

Highly absorbable phosphorus-containing salts, including sodium phosphates and polyphosphates

Used in: Processed cheese and meat, drinks and packaged foods to retain moistureand improve texture

Warning: Excess amounts may harm people with kidney disease. Food-specific limits apply



2 HIGH-FRUCTOSE CORN/ GLUCOSE SYRUP

Concentrated sweetener produced from starch, usually corn

Used in: Soft drinks, sauces, desserts, cereals and processed snacks

Warning: Excess intake can worsen glucose and insulin control, lead to excess calorie intake and increase metabolic risk. No ingredient-specific daily limit yet

3 MALTODEXTRIN

Rapidly digestible carbohydrate made by partially breaking down starch

Used in: Protein powders, seasoning mixes, sauces, instant foods and snacks to add bulk and texture

Warning: Can rapidly raise blood glucose and insulin, but doesn't look or sound like sugar on the label. No universal consumer limit



4 SUCRALOSE

Virtually calorie-free sweetener made by modifying sugar

Used in: 'Zero', 'diet' and no-added-sugar drinks, protein products and desserts

Warning: Long-term impact being studied after small human trial indicates it may cause reduced insulin sensitivity. FSSAI permits it only in specified food categories and at prescribed levels





5 ASPARTAME

Very low-calorie artificial sweetener made from two amino acids

Used in: Diet drinks, chewing gums, tabletop sweeteners and sugar-free foods

Warning: Large studies associate mixtures containing aspartame with higher metabolic risk, though its isolated effect is debated. Limit: 0-40 mg/kg body weight/day



6 ACESULFAME-K

Calorie-free sweetener 200 times sweeter than sugar

Used in: Diet drinks, protein products, desserts and tabletop sweeteners, often combined with other sweeteners

Warning: Studies have associate additive mixtures containing acesulfame-K with higher type-2 diabetes incidence, but its isolated effect is debated. No limit yet